Tirana, 20 October 2026

To Amnesty International, Regional Office for Europe, and the Crisis Response Programme and Crisis Evidence Lab

Subject: Request for an urgent research mission to Albania concerning the policing of the student protests that began on 13 October 2026

Dear colleagues,

We are a group of lawyers and legal experts who have organised ourselves voluntarily to provide legal support to protesters and to engage with institutions at national and international level, and we are writing jointly to ask Amnesty International to send researchers to Albania as soon as possible, while the protests are still continuing and while the evidence can still be gathered. Since 13 October 2026 students, schoolchildren and other citizens have protested in Tirana and at least eight other towns. Some protests turned violent and police officers were injured, and the State was entitled to respond to that violence. What has been documented, however, is something different: force used against people who were already on the ground, restrained, isolated or in custody, arrests carried out by masked men and men in plain clothes without any identification, children arrested and questioned without guardians, and less-lethal weapons used in ways that have caused serious injuries.

We enclose, as a group submission, the report *Albania: request for an urgent research mission*, prepared by Av. Dea Nini, LL.M., one of the members of our group, on the basis of 124 items sent privately by protesters, witnesses and families or published by Albanian media and reviewed frame by frame. The report contains the main findings, a list of priority cases for verification on the ground, specific requests, a visual annex of stills from the footage and photographs of injuries and munitions, and the complete confidential evidence log. A public report by the same author covering 13 to 18 October has already been published and sent to international human rights mechanisms; the material from 18 to 20 October, set out in section 3 of the enclosed report and in entries 94 to 124 of the log, has not been shared before and is presented here for the first time.

The protests are not over. On 18 and 19 October officers were filmed pursuing young people into the grounds of the Orthodox Cathedral in Tirana, entering university lecture halls in Vlorë, spraying irritant into the face of a young man running away and into a café where a journalist and a lawyer were sitting, and pressing a baton across the throat of an unarmed young man. On 20 October a young woman reported that she had been struck on the thigh by a tear gas canister fired directly at her while she was offering water to people affected by gas, and her photographs show a haematoma about 17 cm across. Much of this evidence is fragile: videos are deleted, CCTV recordings are overwritten within days, wounds heal, and recovered munitions are being kept by private individuals with no chain of custody.

We would therefore be grateful if Amnesty International would consider a research mission to Tirana and, if possible, Durrës, Korçë, Lezhë and Vlorë; verification of the open-source material by the Crisis Evidence Lab; identification of the munitions, including expired and

unmarked tear gas cartridges and shells loaded with rubber balls, plastic pellets and possibly buckshot; and, in the meantime, a public statement or communication to the Albanian authorities asking them to preserve evidence, ensure that all officers are individually identifiable and refrain from unnecessary and disproportionate force. Sections 4 and 5 of the enclosed report set out the priority cases and these requests in more detail. The enclosed report is confidential, and its visual annex contains unblurred images, including of a minor, and is not for publication. Private persons are referred to by initials throughout.

Yours sincerely,

On behalf of the group of lawyers and legal experts providing voluntary legal support to protesters

[Names and signatures]

Enclosure: *Albania: request for an urgent research mission*, prepared by Av. Dea Nini, LL.M. (20 October 2026), with visual annex and complete evidence log